

Dear Editors-in-Chief,

On behalf of my co-authors, I am pleased to submit our manuscript entitled “Gamification of history education: a systematic review” for consideration for publication in *Social Sciences & Humanities Open*.

As digital technologies reshape educational landscapes, gamification has emerged as a transformative approach to engaging students with historical content. Our systematic review synthesizes empirical evidence from 74 studies spanning 2000 to 2024, examining the conceptualization, effectiveness, design principles, and implementation challenges of gamification in history education. We highlight how gamified interventions can enhance knowledge acquisition and student engagement while identifying critical gaps in methodological rigor and evidence quality that risk overestimating benefits.

We believe this work aligns strongly with the scope of *Social Sciences & Humanities Open*, particularly its emphasis on educational innovation, pedagogical methodologies, and the societal impacts of technology in learning. Specifically, our manuscript contributes to the field by:

1. Analyzing conceptualizations of gamification in history education, revealing that 85.1% of studies lack explicit definitions and identifying dominant theoretical frameworks such as game-based learning and flow theory.
2. Evaluating effectiveness, with the majority of studies reporting positive outcomes on engagement and knowledge gains, though tempered by high risk of bias in 83.8% of cases.
3. Identifying key design elements (e.g., narrative storytelling, role-playing, and immersive VR/AR) and instructional strategies (e.g., collaborative and inquiry-based learning) for integrating historical content with game mechanics.
4. Documenting implementation barriers, including technical constraints, resource limitations, and equity concerns (e.g., gender disparities in engagement), alongside recommendations for rigorous future research designs.

This manuscript is original, has not been published previously, and is not under consideration for publication elsewhere. All authors have approved the submission. We have declared the use of AI tools (Claude 3.5 Sonnet and GPT-4o) for initial screening and data extraction assistance in the manuscript’s methods section, alongside a statement of no competing interests.

Thank you for considering our manuscript.

Yours sincerely,

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